

■ By Rohit Parihar

The age-old advice for those living in glass houses has never applied anywhere better than in Rajasthan, where a bizarre game of digging up dirt on political rivals has taken on ridiculous proportions. More ridiculous is the fact that with state elections due in exactly a year, the blame game is being played mostly between members of the ruling BJP. For Rajasthan, where inner party squabbles have rarely touched this low, the pre-electoral scene has certainly livened up and the Opposition Congress has been gifted loads

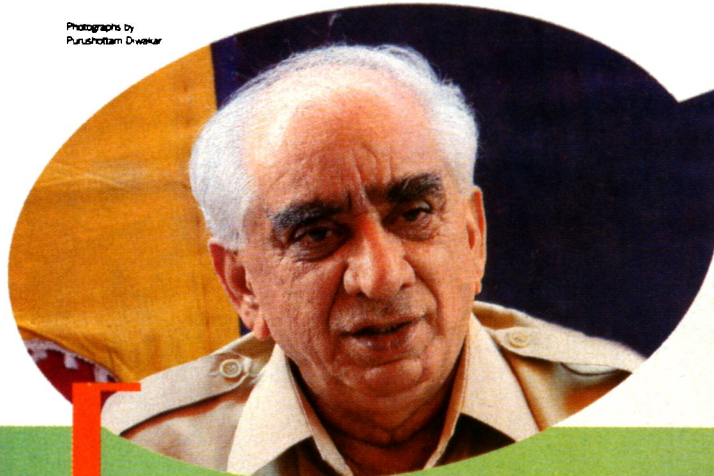
DOSSIER GAMES

Politics in the state is reduced to a theatre of the absurd as BJP politicians indulge in a dirty war, raking up dirt on their party rivals

efforts to get a case lodged against BJP MLA Surya Kanta Vyas, who released a calendar portraying Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje as a deity. Jaswant may have his own reasons to undermine Raje but his wife's act is seen as unwarranted, born out of an ego clash with Raje who she was once close to.

The dossier war has trickled down the ranks and is now part of the struggle between partymen to have a bigger say in the distribution of tickets and has, like in the case of Jaswant's wife, turned a friend into foe. When Raje's Education Minister Ghanshyam Tiwari and others had opposed her for proposing an SEZ near Jaipur, it had caused a serious crisis but, overnight, resistance had melted away with the

Photographs by Punesham D-wakar



"Power has gone into the heads of some and their pride will destroy them." JASWANT SINGH, SENIOR BJP LEADER



"Opponents are levelling charges that are of too low a level for me to react." VASUNDHARA RAJE, CHIEF MINISTER, RAJASTHAN

of ammunition by the enemy.

"This is alien to even Indian culture," says Manvendra Singh, BJP MP from Barmer and son of veteran party leader Jaswant Singh. Father and son are generally perceived as clean and scandal-free leaders, but both are now the target of Rajasthan's newest weapon—the dossier. The dossier doing the rounds accuses them of evading stamp duty on various properties and also of acquiring land illegally at several places in Jodhpur. Already fighting a case where he is facing the charge of having allegedly served opium to guests, Jaswant is getting a taste of his own medicine with the authors of the dossier suspected to be his rivals in the state. He had invited trouble by openly associating with dissidents and his wife Sheetal Kanwar's

Photograph Cartoon



MALICIOUS: Caricatures of Welfare Minister Dilawar (left)

appearance of a special dossier listing alleged misdeeds of the critics. Tiwari himself was forced to publicly defend himself when anonymous papers were circulated that showed him as having "benami" partnerships in dozens of hotels and restaurants, and having vested interests in the land that was being acquired for the SEZ.

Another Raje dissident and the blue-eyed boy of RSS and Bajrang Dal, Social Welfare Minister Madan Dilawar was put in the same position recently when he held a series of press conferences challenging anyone to